# Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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**Abstract**

oindent Sociologists have long debated the nature of "good" and "bad" taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF) to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions. I identify distinct cultural models for "good taste" (e.g., Similar Say Usually, Art Appreciate Quality, Look Appealing Clothing, Pleasing Choices Aesthetically) and "bad taste" (e.g., Likes Different Opinion, Choices Music Clothing, Usually Quality Ugly, Care Really Look). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, specific aesthetic and subjective models are associated with varying propensities to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

# 1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of "good" and "bad" taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

# 2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by four primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define "good taste" and "bad taste"?
2. How do cultural models of good taste cross-tabulate with cultural models of bad taste to form internally coherent, broader cultural logics?
3. Are these cultural models of taste systematically patterned by traditional socio-demographic hierarchies (e.g., age, education, and political orientation)?
4. Does the propensity to draw boundaries (the total volume of differentiated cultural domains) vary significantly depending on the underlying cultural model an individual adopts?

# 3 Methods

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter "documents"), I used **Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF)**. NMF is a linear-algebraic technique that reduces high-dimensional text data into a lower-dimensional set of latent "topics" or cultural models. First, the raw text was converted into an $N \times M$ Document-Term Matrix ($V$), where $N$ is the number of documents and $M$ is the size of the vocabulary. The values in this matrix were computed using Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF), which weights words by how frequently they appear in a specific document while discounting words that are overwhelmingly common across the entire corpus. Specifically, the TF-IDF weight for a term $t$ in a document $d$ within a corpus $D$ is calculated as:

$$\text{TF-IDF}(t, d, D) = \text{tf}(t, d) \cdot \log\left(\frac{N}{|\{d \in D : t \in d\}|}\right) \tag{1}$$

where $\text{tf}(t, d)$ is the raw count of term $t$ in document $d$, and the logarithmic term represents the inverse document frequency. Within this logarithmic term, $N$ is the total number of documents, and the denominator $|\{d \in D : t \in d\}|$ is the absolute count of documents within the entire corpus that contain the term $t$ at least once. This ensures that terms appearing in nearly every document receive a weight close to zero, highlighting only the specific lexical signals that distinguish sub-populations. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., "good," "bad," "taste," "don't") and standard English stop words were removed.

The NMF algorithm then approximates $V$ by factoring it into two lower-rank, strictly non-negative matrices: $W$ and $H$ (such that $V \approx WH$). The $W$ matrix (size $N \times K$) represents the document-topic associations, providing a continuous "soft-assignment" weight of how strongly each respondent's answer aligns with each of the $K$ latent cultural models. The $H$ matrix (size $K \times M$) represents the topic-term associations, indicating the relative importance of each vocabulary word in defining a given cultural model. The algorithm was optimized for each of the two text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring.

Finally, to explore the structural relationships between the documents and the derived topics, I conducted a Correspondence Analysis (CA). The CA was computed directly on the $N \times K$ soft-assignment matrix of document-to-topic probabilities generated by the NMF (with a minimal constant added to prevent division-by-zero errors), visualizing the geometric distance between respondents' nuanced linguistic choices across the components.

## 3.1 Parameter Selection and Model Robustness

To ensure our topic solutions were empirically robust, we evaluated NMF models across a range of component configurations (K). The optimal configuration balances two competing demands: maximizing the granularity of semantic clusters while minimizing reconstruction error. We optimized for a 4-topic solution for both Good Taste and Bad Taste. This configuration prevents the model from collapsing into overly generic models while maintaining distinct qualitative variation.

# 4 Results

## 4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

Figure 2 and Figure 3 display the top ten most distinguishing terms (weighted by their NMF prominence) associated with each model, while Figure 1 shows the sample prevalence of each model. As shown in the term charts, the models are anchored by distinct lexical signatures that reveal different conceptualizations of aesthetic boundary-drawing.

For **Good Taste**, four primary cultural models emerged from the NMF analysis: *Similar Say Usually* (highlighting subjective similarity, driven by terms like "similar," "say," and "usually"), *Art Appreciate Quality* (focusing on elevated aesthetic appreciation and driven by words like "art," "quality," and "appreciate"), *Look Appealing Clothing* (emphasizing visual presentation and curation, characterized by words like "look," "appealing," and "clothing"), and *Pleasing Choices Aesthetically* (centering on innate aesthetic stylishness via terms like "pleasing," "aesthetically," and "choices"). Table 1 and Table 2 present the term arrays and representative qualitative quotes for these models.

| Topic | Count | Name | Representation |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0 | 46 | Similar-Say-Usually | similar, say, usually, likes, opinion, interests, certain... |
| 1 | 99 | Art-Appreciate-Quality | art, appreciate, quality, enjoy, food, way, style... |
| 2 | 39 | Look-Appealing-Clothing | look, appealing, clothing, way, knows, pick, listen... |
| 3 | 40 | Pleasing-Choices-Aesthetically | pleasing, choices, aesthetically, make, stylish, typically, ... |

Table 1: Good Taste Def Summary

| Topic | Name | Representative Document |
|---|---|---|
| 0 | Similar-Say-Usually | "I'd say a person has good taste if I like similar things." |
| 1 | Art-Appreciate-Quality | "What I mean by that is they have a taste similar to mine or one I can appreciate. People who enjoy the same type of books or movies or art. Though I can understand someone may have exceptional taste and I don't agree with it. Such as enjoying Rothko's art or Wharton's novels. " |
| 2 | Look-Appealing-Clothing | "Something that they like has an appealing look" |
| 3 | Pleasing-Choices-Aesthetically | "Their choices are aesthetically pleasing to me. " |

Table 2: Representative Quotes for Good Taste Cultural Models

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through four distinct cultural models that mirror and invert the positive models: *Likes Different Opinion* (emphasizing subjective differences and disagreement via words like "likes," "different," and "opinion"), *Choices Music Clothing* (focusing on poor specific choices in domains like music and clothing), *Usually Quality Ugly* (centering on low quality, cheapness, or ugliness), and *Care Really Look* (highlighting gaudiness, clashing styles, and a general lack of care in appearance or curation, anchored by words like "care," "really," and "look"). Table **??** and Table **??** present the corresponding term summaries and representative quotes.

| Topic | Count | Name | Representation |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0 | 62 | Likes-Different-Opinion | likes, different, opinion, say, art, dislike, interests... |
| 1 | 66 | Choices-Music-Clothing | choices, music, clothing, preferences, shows, food, unappeal... |
| 2 | 50 | Usually-Quality-Ugly | usually, quality, ugly, poor, way, likes, looks... |
| 3 | 46 | Care-Really-Look | care, really, look, colors, items, gaudy, know... |

Table 3: Bad Taste Def Summary

## 4.2 Cross-Cultural Model Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent "logics," I cross-tabulated respondents' primary cultural models across the two questions. The associations are statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 20.88, p < 0.05$). For instance, individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity (*Similar Say Usually*) strongly tend to define bad taste as subjective difference (*Likes Different Opinion*). Likewise, those focused on aesthetics (*Pleasing*

| Topic | Name | Representative Document |
|---|---|---|
| 0 | Likes-Different-Opinion | "When I say that someone has bad taste, it means that in my opinion, the things that person likes is very different from the things I like, so, therefore, they have bad taste." |
| 1 | Choices-Music-Clothing | "Someone who has bad taste in clothing choices, music, food, dating preferences. " |
| 2 | Usually-Quality-Ugly | "Usually it is about gaining noteriety at the expense of quality. It is a the immature desire tp shock others in negative ways and usually means poor quality." |
| 3 | Care-Really-Look | "Someone who has bad taste doesn't really care or even notice how an object is made. It could be junky and poorly finished. This is like an old dented car that was painted by a kid with a spray can of some garish color paint." |

Table 4: Representative Quotes for Bad Taste Cultural Models

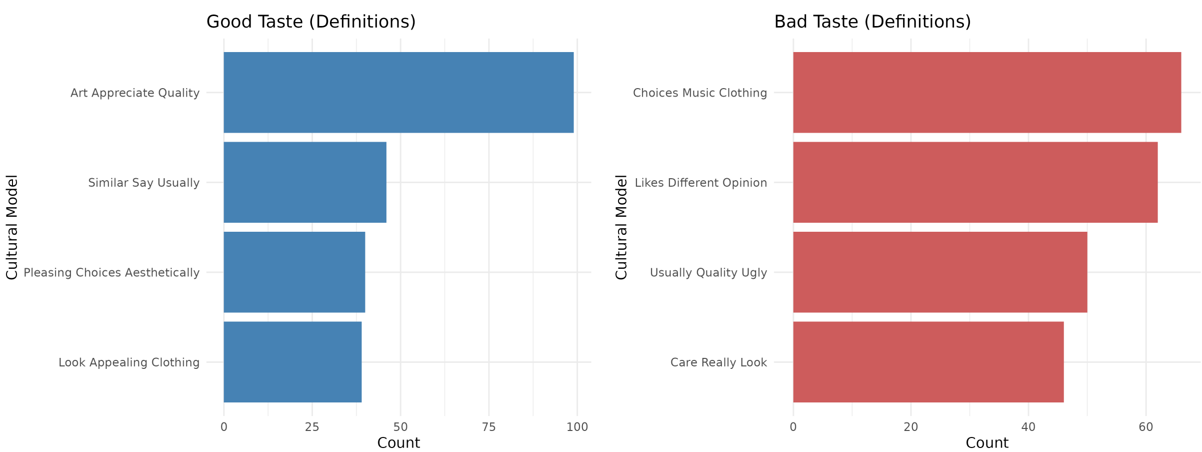


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

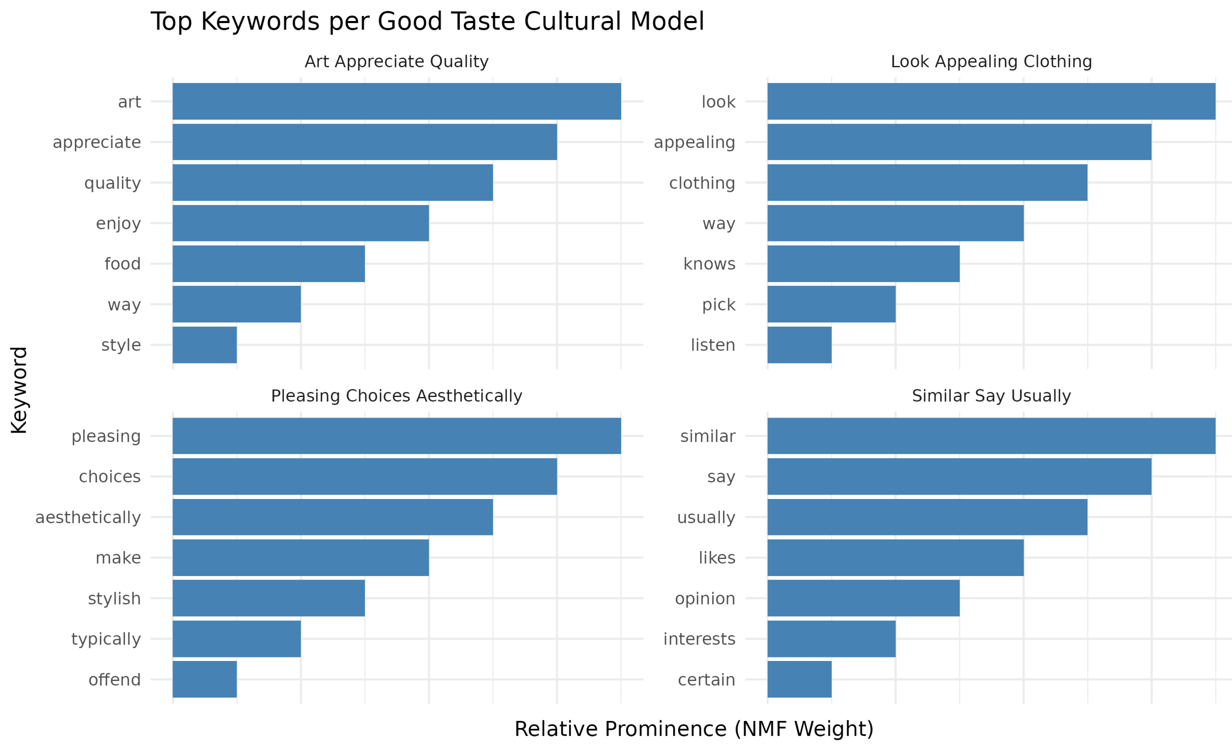


Figure 2: Top Keywords for Good Taste Cultural Models

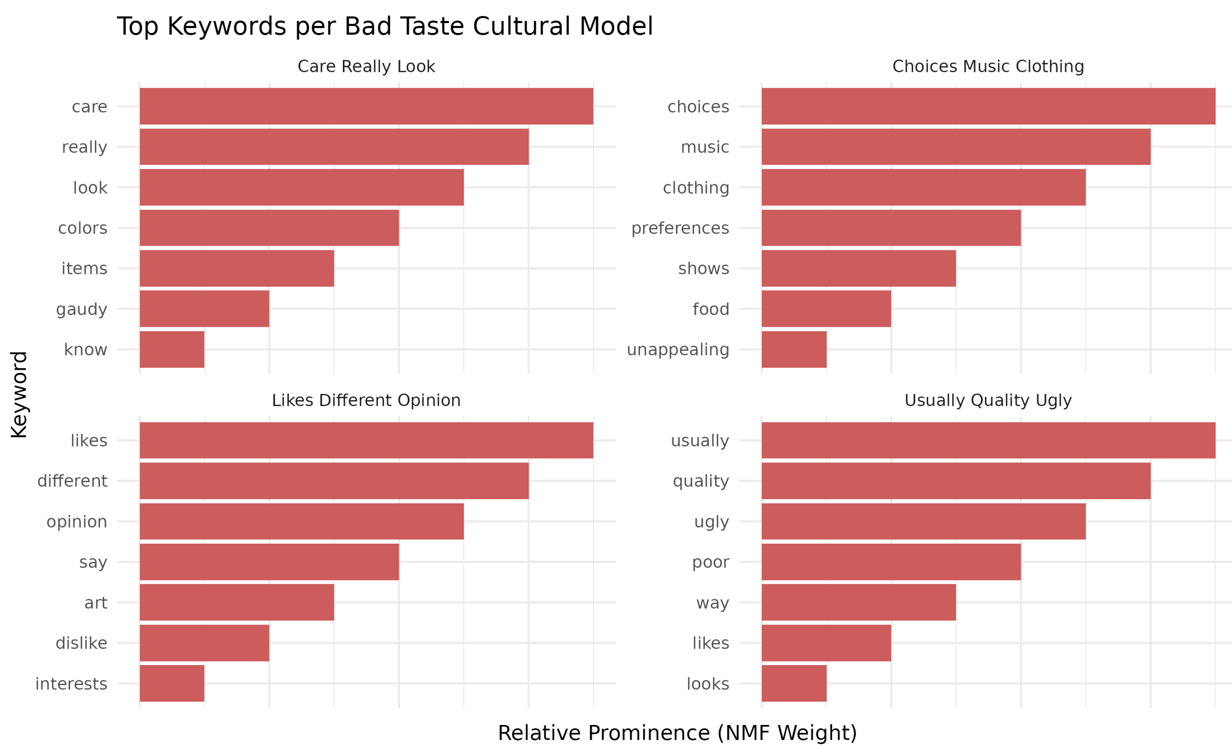


Figure 3: Top Keywords for Bad Taste Cultural Models

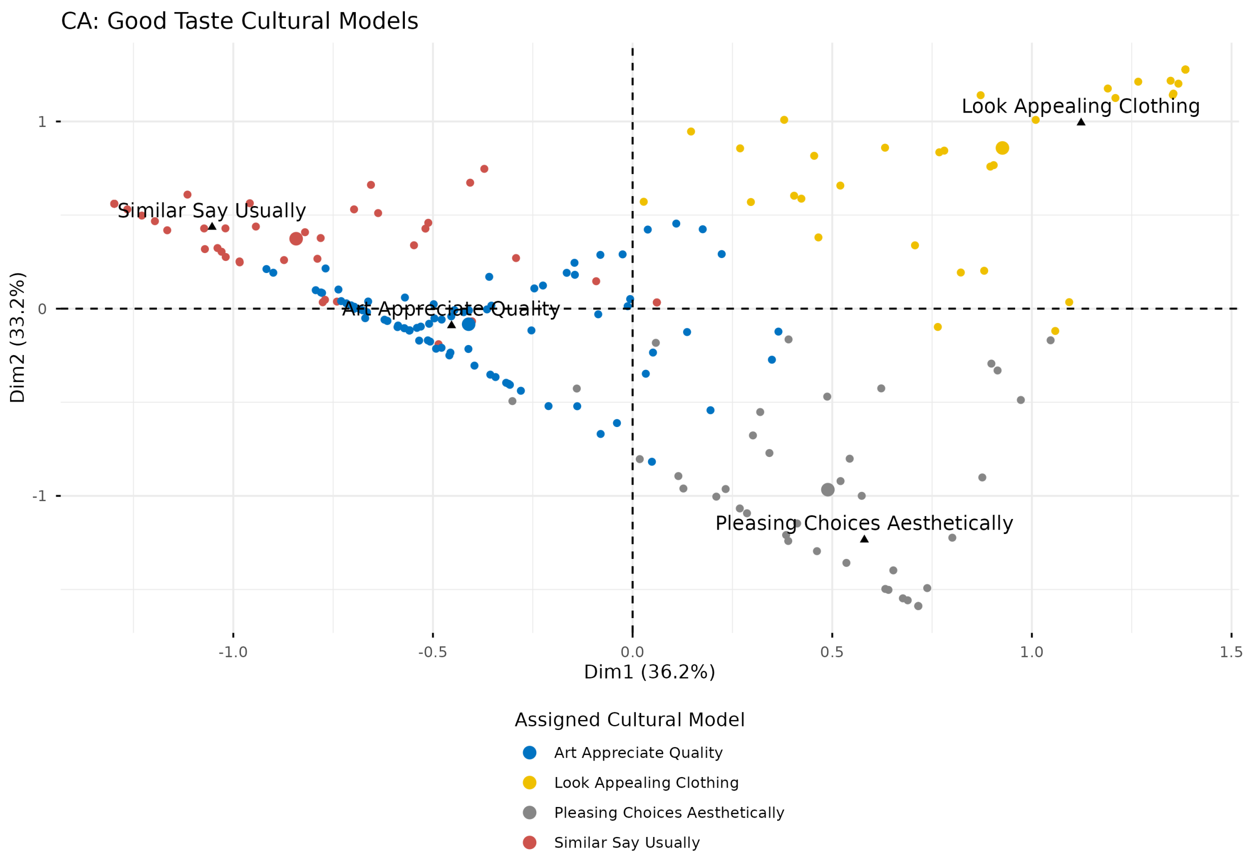


Figure 4: Correspondence Analysis of Good Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

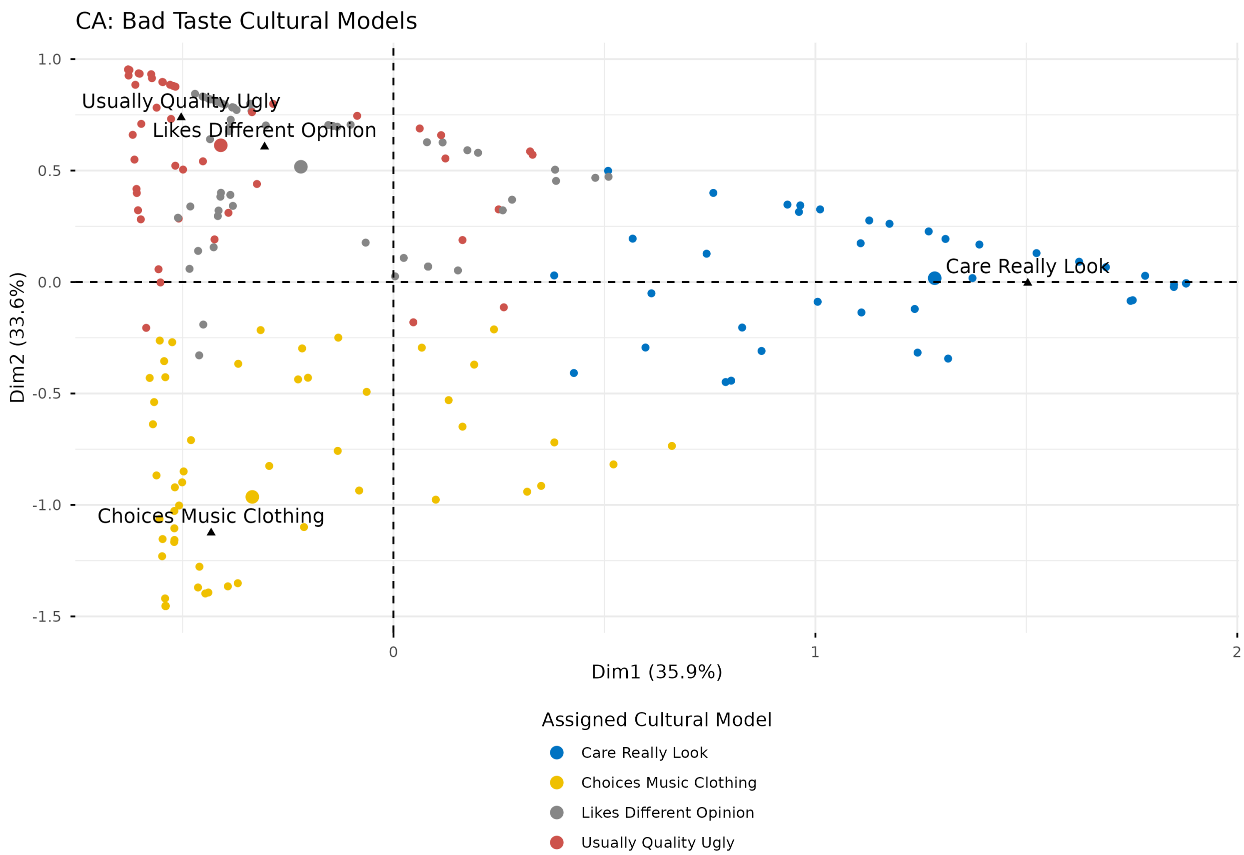


Figure 5: Correspondence Analysis of Bad Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

*Choices Aesthetically*) often define bad taste through the lens of specific choices (*Choices Music Clothing*).

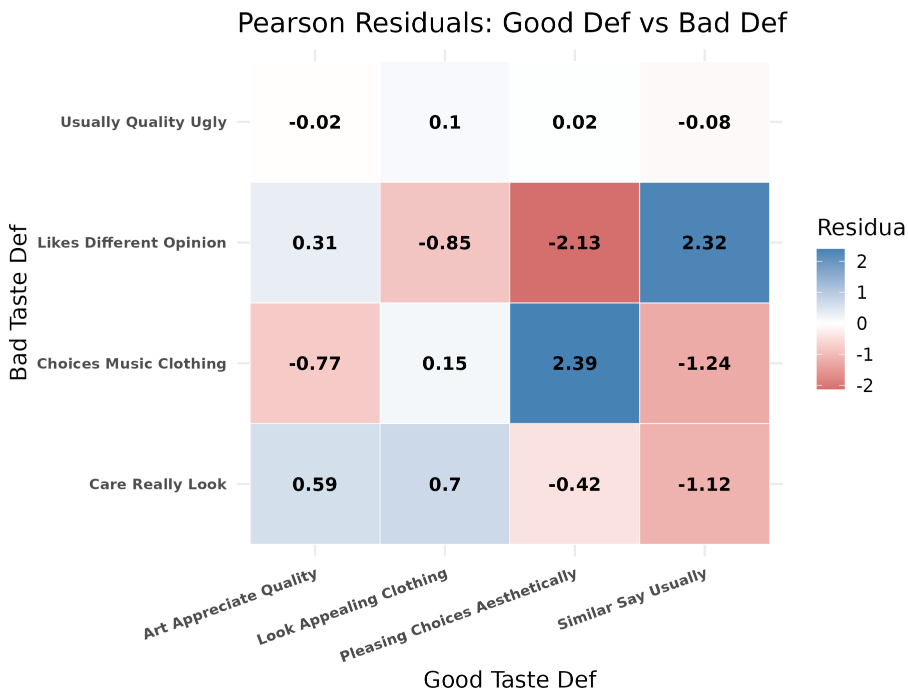


Figure 6: Pearson Residuals: Cross-Tabulation of Good and Bad Taste Cultural Models

## 4.3 Demographics

To examine whether taste cultural models are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents' primary topic cultural model (across both models) using their Age, Gender, Education (factor), Parent's Education (factor), and Political Orientation (a 1–7 continuous scale ranging from extremely liberal to extremely conservative). The Likelihood Ratio $\chi^2$ tests are presented in Table 3.

As shown in Table 3, sociodemographic background strongly structures how respondents conceptualize taste. For the Good Taste models, every single predictor—Age, Gender, Education, Parent's Education, and Political Ideology—is highly significant ($p < 0.05$, with Education and Politics significant at $p < 0.001$). The pattern holds similarly for Bad Taste models, where Age, Gender, Education, and Parent's Education significantly predict topic assignment. Political ideology is the only variable that does not reach statistical significance ($p = 0.10$) when predicting Bad Taste conceptualizations. This indicates that while folk theories of taste are varied, they are not randomly distributed; they map closely onto traditional axes of social stratification.

To further illustrate these significant demographic boundaries without relying on noisy coefficient estimates from small cell counts, Figure 7 and Figure 8 display demographic profile heatmaps for each cultural model. These heatmaps calculate the mean demographic percentage values for each topic and color-code them based on the raw percentage (where

| Model | Predictor | LR $\chi^2$ | Df | $p$-value |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Good Taste Def | Age (Polynomial) | 16.46 | 6 | 0.0115 |
| Good Taste Def | Gender | 15.65 | 3 | 0.0013 |
| Good Taste Def | Education Level | 38.16 | 12 | $< 0.001$ |
| Good Taste Def | Parent's Education | 29.23 | 12 | 0.0036 |
| Good Taste Def | Political Ideology | 24.19 | 3 | $< 0.001$ |
| Bad Taste Def | Age (Polynomial) | 14.96 | 6 | 0.0206 |
| Bad Taste Def | Gender | 8.05 | 3 | 0.0451 |
| Bad Taste Def | Education Level | 26.32 | 12 | 0.0097 |
| Bad Taste Def | Parent's Education | 21.14 | 12 | 0.0484 |
| Bad Taste Def | Political Ideology | 6.25 | 3 | 0.1001 |

Table 5: Multinomial Logistic Regression Likelihood Ratio Tests for Topic Predictors

deeper blue indicates a higher percentage of respondents in that demographic category, and deeper red indicates a lower percentage). For example, Figure 7 demonstrates that respondents holding the *Art Appreciate Quality* good taste model skew distinctly older, more highly educated (both personally and across their parents' generation), and heavily liberal compared to the other groups. In contrast, those adopting the *Look Appealing Clothing* model are the youngest and least likely to have college-educated parents. Similar boundaries emerge in Figure 8, where the *Usually Quality Ugly* bad taste model is uniquely concentrated among highly-educated liberals, while *Choices Music Clothing* appeals to a notably more conservative demographic base.

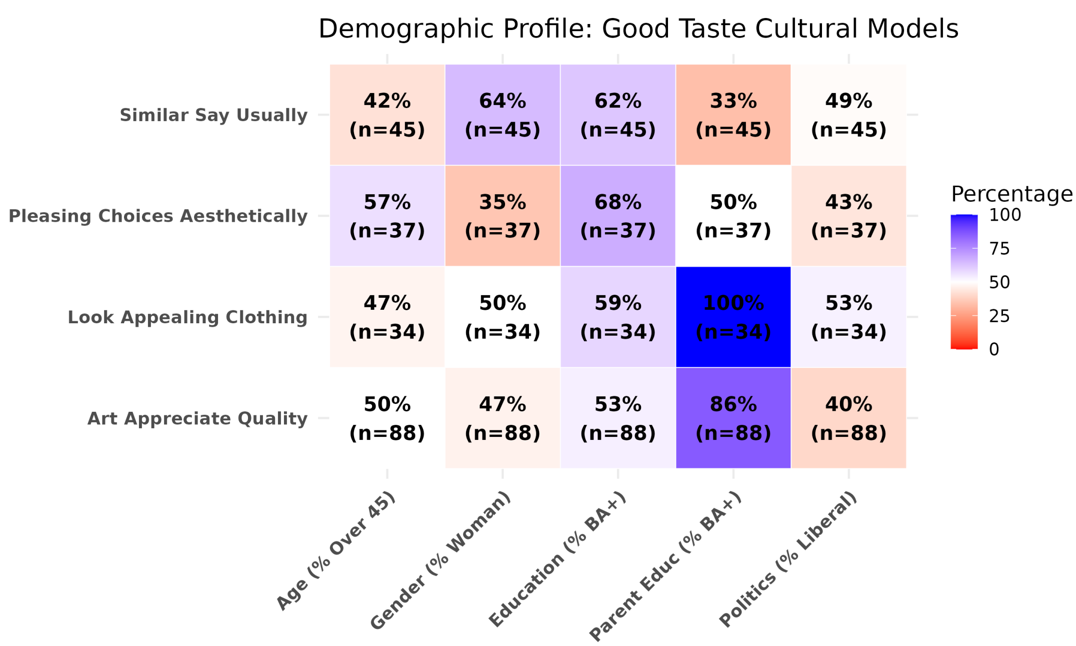


Figure 7: Demographic Profile Heatmap (Good Taste Cultural Models)

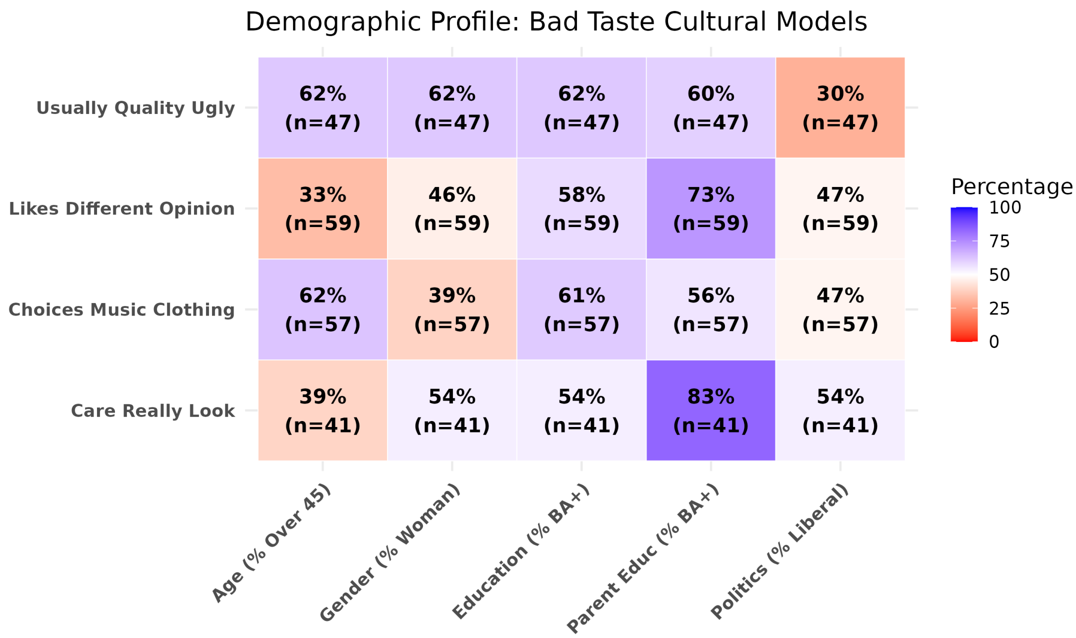


Figure 8: Demographic Profile Heatmap (Bad Taste Cultural Models)

## 4.4 Volume of Domain Distinctions

To assess how broadly respondents apply their taste definitions across cultural domains, I constructed an additive variable representing the total number of domains (out of 19) in which a respondent reported that distinguishing between "good" and "bad" taste made sense (a score of 2 or above).

I ran a one-way ANOVA to test whether the average number of differentiated domains varies depending on the respondent's topic cultural model assignment. The results demonstrate that respondents operating under different cultural models differ significantly in the sheer volume of cultural spaces they subject to aesthetic differentiation. Specifically, this relationship is robust for the *bad taste* cultural models (see Figure 9).

| Predictor | $F$ | num Df | den Df | $p$-value |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Good Taste Def | 0.67 | 3 | 203 | 0.571 |
| Bad Taste Def | 5.64 | 3 | 203 | $0.001^{***}$ |

$^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 6: ANOVA Results: Number of Domains (score $\geq 2$) by Taste Cultural Model.

## 4.5 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it "makes sense" to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

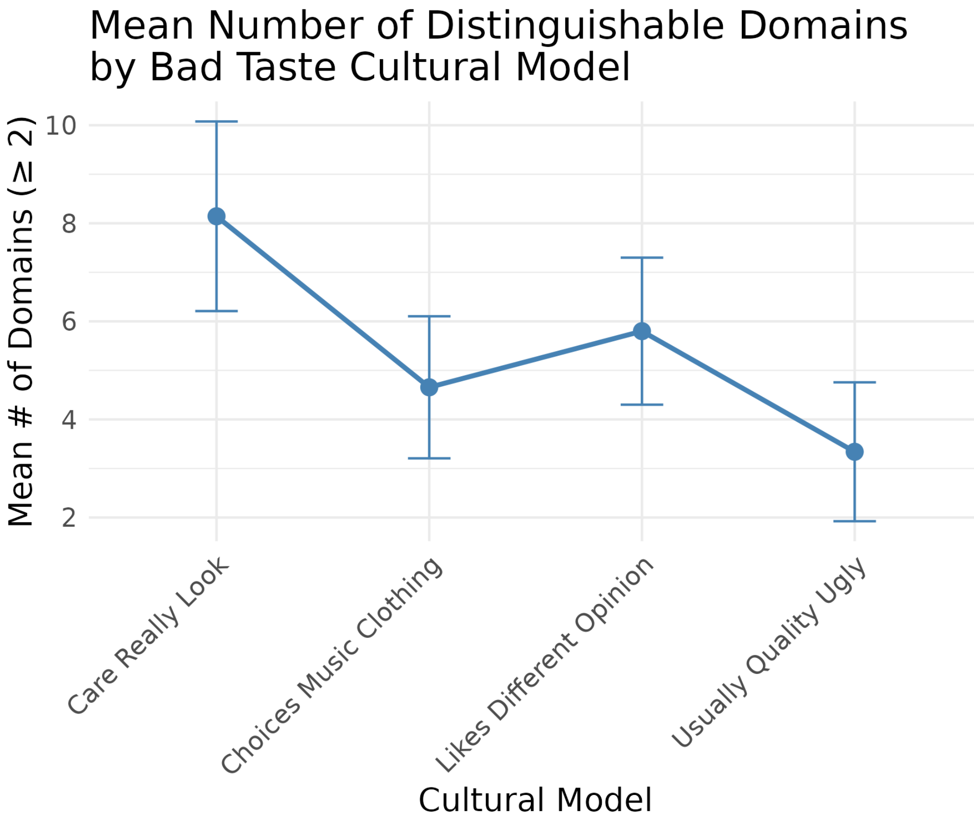


Figure 9: Mean Number of Distinguishable Domains by Bad Taste Cultural Model

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the cultural model, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

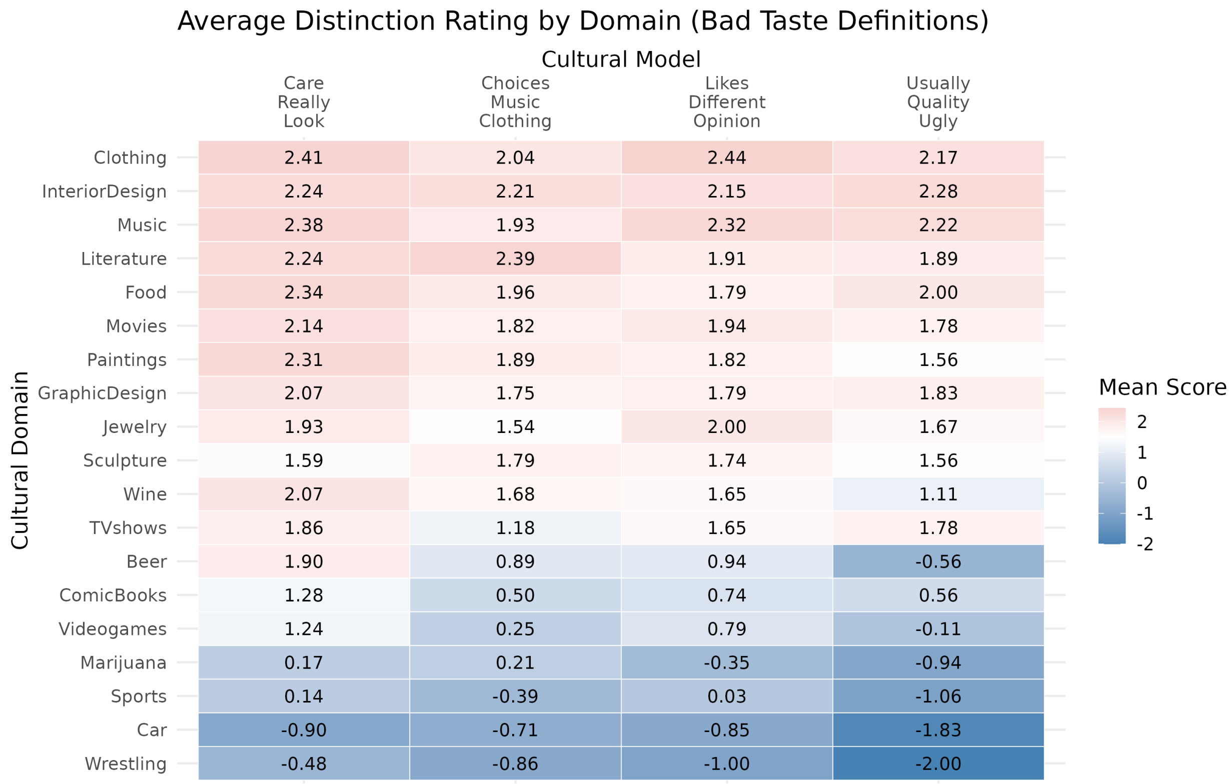


Figure 10: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Cultural Model (Definitions)

# 5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, subjective, and quality-based dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

# References

Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA.

Haak, M. v. d. and Wilterdink, N. (2019). Struggling with distinction: How and why people switch between cultural hierarchy and equality. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 22(4):416–432.

Jarness, V. and Friedman, S. (2017). 'i'm not a snob, but...': Class boundaries and the downplaying of difference. *Poetics*, 61:14–25.